

Lubricants and moisturizers are simple products without hormones. They ease vaginal dryness, irritation and pain with sex. You can buy them without a prescription. You can use them alone or along with vaginal estrogen. The two do different jobs, so it helps to know which one to use.

Lubricant or Moisturizer?

- **Lubricant:** used **at the time of sex** to make things slippery and reduce rubbing and pain. It works for a short time. Add more as needed.
- **Moisturizer:** used **on a regular schedule**, whether or not you have sex. It keeps the tissue moist over time.

Many people use **both**: a moisturizer for everyday comfort and a lubricant during sex.

Choosing a Type

- **Water-based:** easy to wash off, but dries out quickly.
- **Silicone-based:** lasts longer and does not dry out. Do not use with silicone sex toys. Check the label before using it with a silicone pessary or vaginal ring.
- **Oil-based:** lasts long, but **breaks down latex and polyisoprene condoms**. It may also raise the chance of vaginal infections.

If you use condoms, check the product and condom labels to be sure they can be used together.

Learn the Terms

Lubricant

A product used during sex to reduce rubbing.

Moisturizer

A product used regularly to keep the tissue moist.

Water-based

Easy to wash off. May need adding again.

Silicone-based

Lasts longer. Not for use with silicone toys.

GSM

Dryness and thinning of the vagina after menopause. A common cause of dryness.

Osmolality

How “concentrated” a product is. Very concentrated products may irritate.

Do I still need estrogen? Not always. For many people, these products are enough for dryness and painful sex. They are a good choice if you want to avoid hormones. But they have not been shown to help bladder symptoms or prevent urine infections. If dryness is from menopause, **vaginal estrogen** can be used instead or added. You do not have to try these products first.

How to Use Them

- **Lubricant:** apply just before and during sex, to yourself and your partner. Add more as needed.
- **Moisturizer:** put it in the vagina on a **regular schedule**, most often 2 or 3 times a week. Follow the product's directions.

Choosing Gentle Products

- Choose products that are **unscented**, with no warming or tingling added. These can irritate.
- Avoid products with spermicide if you get irritated.
- If a product stings, switch to another. Everyone reacts differently.
- With **latex or polyisoprene condoms**, do not use oil-based products.

Good to Know

- You can use them for as long as they help.
- They can make a pessary (a vaginal support device) more comfortable.
- **Trying to get pregnant?** In lab tests, some lubricants slowed sperm. Effects on pregnancy are not known. Ask your team which product to use.

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- Dryness or irritation that **does not get better**
- Burning, itching, or unusual **discharge**
- Any **bleeding**, especially after menopause or after sex

Go to an emergency department if:

- You have heavy vaginal bleeding, such as soaking a pad an hour
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. Lubricants are for **during sex**. Moisturizers are used **regularly**. Many people use both.
2. Pick a gentle, unscented product that works with your condoms and toys.
3. Vaginal estrogen can be added if these are not enough.